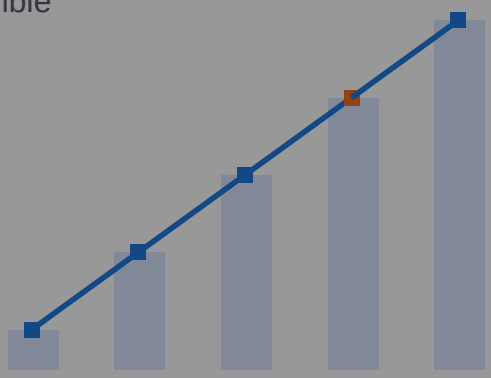
EXECUTIVETALENTINTELLIGENCE

SEASON 1 / INTRODUCTION

How Do Enterprises Identify Leaders Who Create Value?

Vaughn Berger / Independent Research

Research on enterprise hiring, recruiting decisions and credible leadership evidence - followed by actual measured results.



Independent / AI-assisted / Evidence-led

How Do Enterprises Identify Leaders Who Create Value?

Executive Talent Intelligence Season 1 Introduction - independent research by Vaughn Berger

What if a qualified executive and an enterprise recruiter are looking at the same opportunity, yet each sees a different set of signals? The candidate sees years of results, relationships and operational decisions. The recruiting team sees a role definition, an application, a limited review window and many competing priorities. Neither perspective is unreasonable. The challenge is turning professional experience into evidence of future business value.

That is the problem I intend to investigate-starting with my own executive job search.

Abstract

Executive Talent Intelligence is a personally motivated, AI-assisted research project examining how major U.S. employers define, recognize and validate leadership talent. Rather than beginning with assumptions about resumes or applicant tracking systems, the inquiry starts with organizational needs and traces how those needs are translated into hiring decisions. This introduction presents current U.S. workforce data, explains the method and its limitations, and commits to reporting implementation results-even when they challenge the original premise.

Keywords: executive talent; enterprise recruiting; talent acquisition; applicant tracking systems; leadership evidence; skills-based hiring

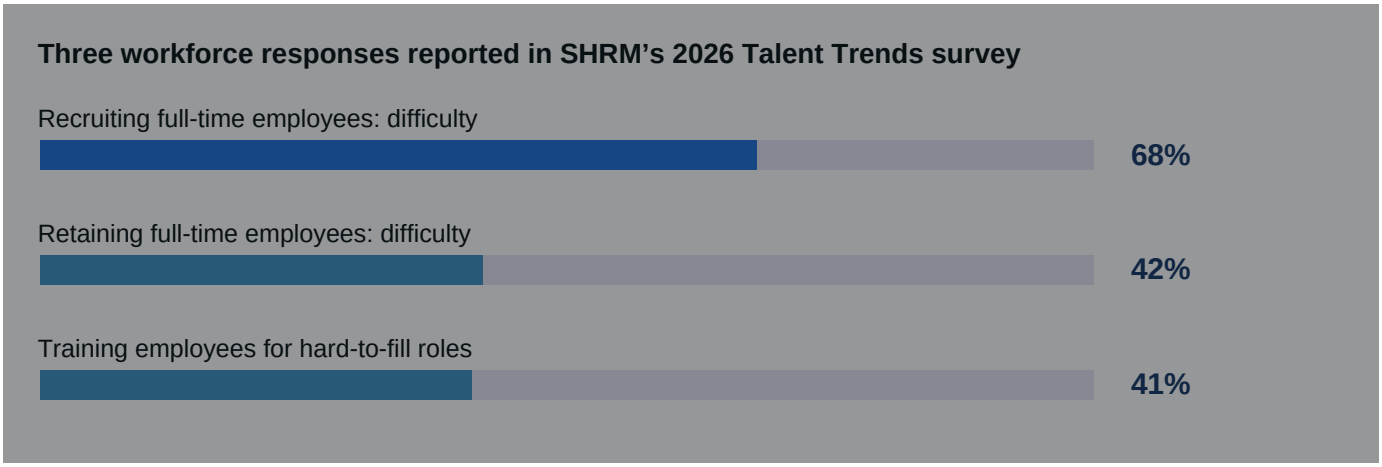
Why study hiring from both sides?

In April 2026, SHRM reported that 68% of 2,094 surveyed U.S. HR professionals experienced difficulty recruiting for full-time positions. Among the respondents reporting recruiting difficulty, 53% said it had become harder than one year earlier. These findings cover organizations across industries and sizes; they do not measure executive recruitment specifically. SHRM, 2026.

That distinction matters. A company’s struggle to hire technical staff, frontline workers or senior executives may have different causes. A broad recruiting statistic cannot answer why a particular executive candidate was or was not invited to interview.

Yet the survey highlights a shared reality: employers have consequential staffing decisions to make, and experienced professionals need a credible way to communicate what they can contribute.

The evidence we have-and what it does not prove



Source: SHRM, April 27, 2026. n=2,094 U.S. HR professionals; fielded Feb. 9-20, 2026. Categories are distinct and may overlap; not executive-specific.

The accompanying figure shows three responses from the same SHRM survey: 68% reported difficulty recruiting full-time workers, 42% reported difficulty retaining them, and 41% said they train existing employees for hard-to-fill roles. The categories are answers to different questions, not mutually exclusive groups. The data are unweighted and self-reported, so they describe participating HR professionals-not a representative census of U.S. employers. SHRM, 2026.

These figures suggest that hiring is part of a broader workforce problem. They do not show which executive qualifications predict performance, how a particular applicant system ranks candidates, or whether resume changes improve interview rates.

SHRM's separate 2026 Finding Talent research surveyed 1,268 U.S. recruitment specialists and examined skills-based hiring, recruiter-hiring manager partnership, and the use of technology in recruiting. Its published methodology includes December 17, 2025-January 26, 2026 field dates. It provides direction for further investigation, not proof of a universal executive-hiring workflow. SHRM, 2026.

A different approach to the job search

My professional background spans enterprise business development, operations, and technology-enabled process improvement. In those roles, the most useful questions often came before the proposed solution: What outcome are we trying to achieve? What evidence would change our decision? Which assumptions have we not tested?

I am applying that discipline to an unfamiliar problem in a very personal setting.

The research will examine enterprise hiring economics, the actual decision steps between application and interview, documented ATS capabilities, leadership requirements, and a sample of current job requisitions. It will then compare those requirements with verifiable professional accomplishments and test different ways of presenting that evidence.

Crucially, the plan does not end with a better-looking resume. It ends with implementation, verified applications, measured first-interview outcomes and documented lessons. A disappointing or inconclusive result will be reported as such.

Three takeaways at the starting line

- Hiring difficulty is not one-dimensional. Recruiting, retention and internal development all appear in current workforce research; executive hiring needs its own evidence.
- Systems should be investigated, not mythologized. We will distinguish what a recruiting product can do from what an employer actually configures and uses.
- Evidence must survive scrutiny. A candidate's claims, an employer's requirements and the eventual application outcomes must all be traceable before we call the experiment successful.

An invitation to examine the question

I will share the method and the results openly, using AI to assist with research and drafting while retaining responsibility for source verification and conclusions. The purpose is to learn from employers and applicants, not to assign blame or imply that one formula can solve every career transition.

For hiring leaders and executive recruiters: what evidence most helps you distinguish a promising senior candidate from someone whose experience merely sounds relevant?

Explore the research: Executive Talent Intelligence on GitHub.

Open the public research repository

PDF articles available for download.

Coming next in Season 1 Research 1:8

What does hiring really cost an enterprise? The next planned investigation will examine how vacancy, hiring quality, and business priorities shape recruiting decisions. Planned; no findings or publication date are implied.

References

1. SHRM. 2026 Talent Trends Report, press release, April 27, 2026. U.S. HR professional survey, n=2,094, February 9-20, 2026. https://www.shrm.org/about/press-room/shrm-unveils-2026-talent-trends-report--data-driven-insights-for

2. SHRM. Finding Talent: Rethinking Recruitment for Today's Dynamic Labor Market, press release, April 28, 2026. U.S. HR/recruitment specialist survey, n=1,268, December 17, 2025-January 26, 2026. https://www.shrm.org/about/press-room/shrm-unveils-finding-talent--rethinking-recruitment-for-today-s-